

# Eating disorders

Eating disorders are emotional mental-health problems that include an extreme relationship with food. Most revolve around an obsessive focus on weight and body shape, which can damage health and may even be life-threatening.

Although they can occur at any life stage, eating disorders usually develop among adolescent and young-adult age groups. The three most common types are anorexia nervosa (or simply anorexia), bulimia nervosa (bulimia), and binge-eating disorder (BED; see panel, below). Diagnosis involves psychological evaluation as well as physical examinations, such as blood tests and measuring the person's body mass index (BMI).

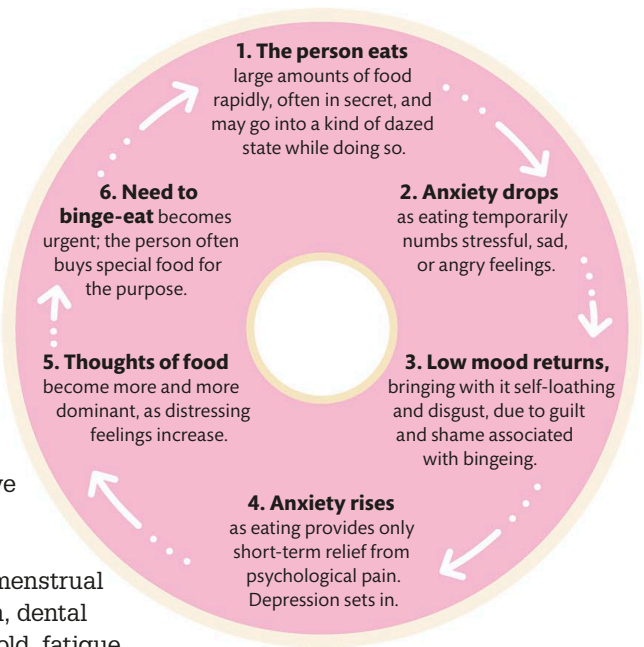
Anorexia always involves weight loss, and a very low BMI is usually flagged in diagnosis. Those affected by both bulimia and BED do not tend to have a low BMI and may be slightly overweight. Eating-disorder symptoms include a preoccupation with weight and body shape, avoiding food-based

activities, eating very little or overeating then purging (self-induced vomiting), extreme use of laxatives, and exercising too much. Sufferers may also have stomach problems, an abnormal weight for their age and height, menstrual problems or disruption, dental issues, sensitivity to cold, fatigue, or dizziness.

## Underlying factors

The causes of eating disorders are not fully understood, but those affected are more likely to have a family member with a history of eating disorders, depression, substance misuse, or addiction. Social pressure and criticism may contribute to a focus on eating habits, body shape, or weight. Some occupations, such as ballet-dancing, acting, sports, or modeling, where there is a focus on

| TYPES OF EATING DISORDERS |                                                                                                                                    |
|---------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| DISORDER                  | DESCRIPTION                                                                                                                        |
| Anorexia nervosa          | Mainly affects young women. Involves an obsessive desire to maintain a low body weight by eating little and overexercising.        |
| Bulimia nervosa           | Bingeing and purging occur in this disorder. The body weight is often normal, but bulimics possess a severely negative self-image. |
| Binge-eating disorder     | Regular excessive eating, usually planned and consumed rapidly and in secret, is followed by intense guilt and shame.              |



## The bingeing cycle

Those with a binge-eating disorder use food to numb emotional pain instead of addressing its psychological cause positively. The result is a destructive cycle.

being slim, are likely to have a higher number of people with eating disorders than other professions. People with eating disorders may also suffer from anxiety, low self-esteem, perfectionism, and sexual abuse. Treatment includes nutritional education, psychological or talking therapies, and group programs.

## FEMALE BIAS

In the US, and many other countries, more women than men are diagnosed with eating disorders. However, the prevalence in men may be underestimated because they are less likely than women to seek help.

